1590 ▸ 1610

Looking closely
See pages 84–85

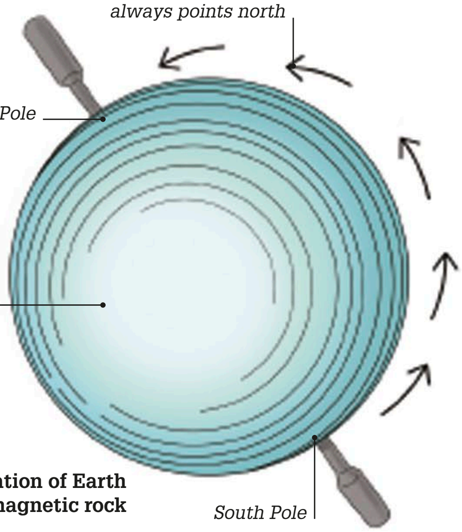

Illustration of Earth as a magnetic rock

1600

Giant magnet

English scientist William Gilbert believed that Earth must have a huge magnet inside because navigators' compasses always pointed north. He made models of Earth from magnetic rock and found that compass needles held close to the rock pointed toward the model's North Pole, behaving just like real compass needles on Earth.

1590

Inventing the microscope

Dutch spectacles-maker Zacharias Janssen is credited with inventing the compound microscope. He inserted two lenses into a tube and looked through one end. Small objects at the other end appeared nine times larger.

Replica of Janssen's original microscope

1600

Burned at the stake

Giordano Bruno, an Italian friar and mathematician, was burned at the stake as a heretic by the Catholic Church. Influenced by Copernicus's ideas of Earth revolving around the Sun, Bruno had argued that the Sun was not the center of the Universe because the Universe was infinite, and that Earth was unlikely to be the only inhabited world.

1590 — 1595

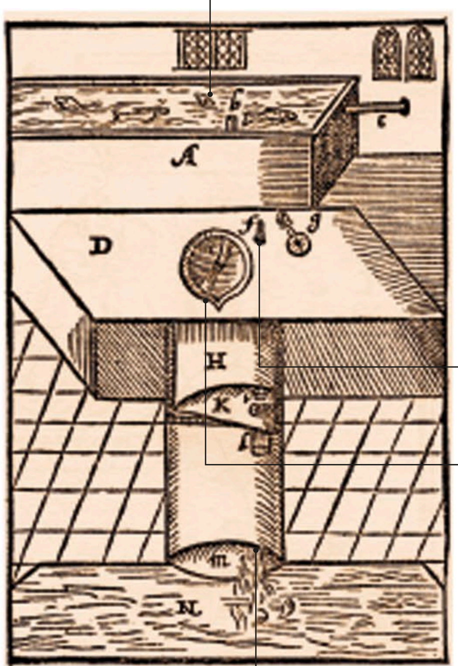

Illustration of Harington's water closet, 1596

1596

Flush toilet

Sir John Harington, a member of Queen Elizabeth's court, invented a flush toilet, called the Ajax. It worked much like a modern toilet except that the water swept the contents of the pan straight into a pit below. Sadly, his invention did not catch on. Hygienic, flushing toilets did not come into use for another three centuries.

"It would make unsavory Places sweet… and filthy Places cleanly."

Sir John Harington, describing his flush toilet

1596

Puzzle of continents

After noting that their coastlines seemed to fit together like pieces of a jigsaw puzzle, Flemish mapmaker Abraham Ortelius suggested that the continents of Africa and the Americas were once joined together. This idea would be confirmed by the theory of continental drift developed by German geophysicist Alfred Wegener in 1915 (see p.170).

World maps, such as this one from 1590, could have inspired Ortelius's theory.